epigraphs provide dates wholly in relation to the starting year of their reign, with the additional provision of a second date which measures time over a relatively longer duration, often calculated according to a continuous political era. So, had Ashoka used a system of reckoning in this form, both regnal and dynastic, the time that elapsed between the accession of his grandfather Chandragupta and Ashoka's own consecration may well have been precisely known.

Ashoka's 'dates' figure in the astonishing number of his imperial texts that were inscribed on stone, rock faces, and pillars. On them the emperor offered all kinds of information, ranging from what was cooked in the royal kitchen to his distaste for inane social ceremonies. The epigraphs are frequently long, and the insights that they provide about his later life, his aspirations, and those of his administration and his subjects, are often communications in the first person: the emperor is addressing us. This in part is what has raised expectations among historians of this stoneware yielding something about Ashoka's early life. These expectations have been dashed. There is not even passing mention of any milestones relating to Ashoka's princely years; he does not speak of his ancestors, nor even of his own parents.[9] Epigraphs in later centuries are known to have expansively described the lineages of rulers who had had royal messages recorded. Even the lineages of previous and present queen-consorts sometimes appear, alongside details of victories in battle, which are often attributed by the kings to the gods and goddesses that they worshipped. Such inscriptions occasionally mention the life of the royal protagonist before he became king. This is so in the first century BCE Hathigumpha epigraph of Kharavela, the ruler of Kalinga who led successful campaigns against Magadha, Anga, and the Tamil region. There, an entire verse is devoted to the prince's training and learning: 'for fifteen years, with a body ruddy and handsome were played youthsome sports; after that (by him who) had mastered (royal) correspondence, currency, finance, civil and religious laws